

work that concerned Wagner-Jauregg throughout his working life was the endeavour to cure mental disease by inducing a fever.”³³

Penicillin eventually made malariotherapy for syphilis patients obsolete, thank goodness. But Wagner-Jauregg is one of the only doctors in history who not only recognized fever’s role in fighting infection, but also prescribed it as a treatment.

Fevers have always been as feared as they are mysterious. Ancient Romans worshiped Febris, the Goddess who protected people from fevers. Amulets were left at temples to placate her, hoping to stave off the next round of shivers.

But Wagner-Jauregg was onto something. Fevers are not accidental nuisances. They *do* play a role in the body’s road to recovery. We now have better, more scientific evidence of fever’s usefulness in fighting infection. A one-degree increase in body temperature has been shown to slow the replication rate of some viruses by a factor of 200. “Numerous investigators have identified a better outcome among patients who displayed fever,” one NIH paper writes.³⁴ The Seattle Children’s Hospital includes a section on its website to educate parents who may panic at the slightest rise in their child’s temperature: “Fevers turn on the body’s immune system. They help the body fight infection. Normal fevers between 100° and 104° F are good for sick children.”³⁵

But that’s where the science ends and reality takes over.

Fever is almost universally seen as a bad thing. They’re treated with drugs like Tylenol to reduce them as quickly as they appear. Despite millions of years of evolution as a defense mechanism, no parent, no patient, few doctors, and certainly no drug company views fever as anything but a misfortune that should be eliminated.

These views do not match the known science. One study was blunt: “Treatment of fever is common in the ICU setting and likely related to standard dogma rather than evidence-based practice.”³⁶ Howard Markel, director of the Center for the History of Medicine, once said of fever phobia: “These are cultural practices that spread just as widely as the infectious diseases that are behind them.”³⁷